THE LETTERS OF THE RAMBAM

Are We Ruled by the Stars? The Rambam's Letter on Astrology, Part 1

The Letters of the Rambam (2025)

Source: Igrot HaRambam: the Letter to the Sages of Montpellier on Astrology (written in Hebrew, c. 1194–95)

Shiur: Second class in the series on the Rambam's letters, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 28 January 2025

These notes are based on the Sofer.ai transcript of the recording.

Recap

Last week: an introduction to the letters, and the three letters to **Ovadia the convert**: the convert's liturgy, free will, and Islam (plus encouragement to the convert).

Background to the Letter

Title	The Letter to the Sages of **Montpellier**, or **על גזירת הכוכבים**, on astrology
Date	**1194 or 1195**, about ten years before the Rambam's death
Asked by	**Rabbi Yonatan HaKohen of Lunel** (born 1135) and his colleagues
Language	**Hebrew**, so we have "the Rambam's own words, unfiltered"
Place	Some editions say Marseille; **Rav Yitzchak Shilat**, today the main authority on the letters, proves it was Montpellier

Rabbi Yonatan HaKohen of Lunel

- A prominent **Tosafist**, born in **Lunel** in 1135, who moved later in life to Montpellier.
- A contemporary of the **Ra'avad**, the Rambam's great critic, yet he **revered** the Rambam and wrote a work defending him from the Ra'avad's critiques.
- **The first known letter from the Rambam to Provence.** He had corresponded with Yemen long before; a follow-up letter came a couple of years later.
- At his request the Rambam sent the **Moreh Nevuchim** (in Shmuel **ibn Tibbon**'s Hebrew translation), which spread through Provence in the late 1190s.

Lunel: the moon

The Rambam opens with a verse from Shir HaShirim:

מי זאת הנשקפה כמו שחר, יפה כלבנה, ברה כחמה

Who is this that looks forth like the dawn, **beautiful as the moon**, clear as the sun?

Lunel, *lunar*, *moon*: "You from Lunel are beautiful as the moon."

A letter into a storm

Provence had both **staunch supporters and staunch opponents** of the Rambam. The two great controversies came after his death:

1. **1232:** in Montpellier itself, **Rabbi Shlomo of Montpellier**, also a Tosafist, led a **ban** on the Rambam's philosophical works, and **Rabbeinu Yonah** led the **burning** of his books. He later admitted he had been wrong, and many say he wrote **Sha'arei Teshuvah** as his repentance.

2. **Late 1200s:** a second controversy, involving the **Rashba**, with the **Meiri** among the Rambam's great defenders.

"Ultimately, history clearly showed that the Rambam was the winner." Three things in this letter would have **delighted his supporters and infuriated his opponents**:

1. How to relate to **Greek and philosophical wisdom**.

2. His willingness to **dismiss certain statements of the Sages** that contradict reason.

3. His **great appreciation for non-Jewish philosophers**.

Part 1: "You Haven't Received My Mishneh Torah"

He begins with warm greetings (**"my chiefs and my teachers"**) and praises the question as testimony to **"the purity of their hearts and the clarity of their minds."**

The question has many branches, but it all comes back to one principle: what is our view of astrology?

It must be that you haven't yet received my book, which explains all the laws of the Torah. I already answered this in **Hilchot Avodah Zarah**, in **Sefer HaMada**. It has already spread **east** (Iraq) and **west** (Morocco, Spain, Yemen), and recently to **Sicily**; it will reach you soon.

There is evidence the Mishneh Torah *had* reached Provence in the early 1190s. Perhaps the Rambam is **subtly chastising** them for not paying it more attention. Still, he answers.

(The Rambam "had different personalities": as a **philosopher** his magnum opus is the *Moreh*; as a **halachist**, the way the yeshivah world sees him, it's the **Mishneh Torah**.)

Part 2: The Three Sources of Knowledge

דעו רבותי, שאין ראוי לאדם להאמין אלא אחד משלושה דברים

Know, my teachers, that a person should only believe one of three kinds of things:

#	Source	Examples
1	**Clear proof of reason**	**Arithmetic, geometry, the calculation of the seasons**: one right answer, "like a maths exam"
2	**The five senses**	This is red, this is black; sweet or bitter; hot or cold; a clear or an echoing voice; a good or bad smell
3	**Tradition** from the **prophets** or the **righteous**	

Rav Saadiah Gaon says the same in the introduction to *Emunot VeDeot* (learned over a year ago), with a fourth category, **inference**, which the Rambam would fold into reason.

Audit your beliefs

Anyone who believes something outside these three, **הפתי יאמין לכל דבר**: "the fool believes everything."

The Rambam's challenge: **sit down one day, list your firm beliefs, and categorise each one.**

Example: Australia. Some of us have been there (the senses). Most of us believe it exists through **tradition**: decent people with no reason to lie. Or **reason**: goods arrive from there. If a belief fits none of the three, you may *wonder*, but you can't hold it as truth.

"One of the worst illnesses"

The fools have written **thousands of books** on astrology… Many people are **great in years but not in wisdom**; they wasted their lives on these books, thought these trivialities were wisdom, and imagined themselves wise.

The mistake of most of the world, except a very few: **they think whatever is written in a book is true**, and all the more so if the book is old.

"We hear this all the time: it's written, it's in the book. So what?" ("He's probably being hyperbolic about the thousands of books.")

Why we lost the Temple

> **וזה הוא שאבד מלכותנו והחריב מקדשנו**: this is what **destroyed our kingdom and our Temple** and brought us to this exile. Our ancestors studied the books of the astrologers (rooted in idolatry), thought them great wisdom, and **did not train for war or conquest**, thinking astrology would protect them. That's why the prophets called them fools, "and indeed they were fools".

"This is incredible." We usually say the Temple fell because of idolatry, the three cardinal sins, baseless hatred. "All true. But ultimately it comes down to a **lack of self-determination**." If life is run by the stars, why train an army? "Warfare doesn't matter; everything is decreed by which constellation you're under."

Part 3: "I Read Every Book on Idolatry in Arabic"

I have investigated these matters a great deal… **I don't think there is a single book translated into Arabic on idolatry that I haven't read and fully understood.**

"How on earth did the Rambam find the time, alongside everything he wrote, all the Torah he knew, and his medical career? This is why he's one of the greatest people of all time."

The halachic problem

In the **Mishneh Torah** (Avodah Zarah 2:2) the Rambam himself writes: the idolaters wrote many books on their worship, and **Hashem commanded us not to read them at all**, not even to think about them. How could he read every one?

Answer	Source
He did it **for the perplexed**: to refute their supposed proofs he had to know them (**Moreh Nevuchim**, the "guide for the *nevuchim*"; **נבוכים הם בארץ**, Pharaoh's word for the Israelites in next week's parasha, Beshalach, the source of the Yiddish *nebech*)	**Rivash**, responsum 45 (a participant's suggestion too: to protect the Jewish people)
The prohibition is reading them **out of interest**; studying them to know what idolatry is, and to stay away from it, is permitted	**Meiri**, probably the Rambam's own view

What he learned: the reasons for the mitzvot

From them I came to understand **the reasons for many mitzvot** that people think have no reason, and I wrote a whole book on this in Arabic.

That is **Part III of the Moreh**, which goes through the mitzvot and explains them.

Chukim aren't reasonless

The common view: there are three categories of mitzvot:

Category	Description
משפטים, judgements	Basic decency: we'd have legislated them ourselves
mitzvot shim'iyot (Rav / **עדות** Saadiah's term)	We wouldn't have thought of them (Shabbat, Pesach) but their reason is apparent once given
חוקים, "statutes"	**"No reason"**: the archetype is **parah adumah**, of which Shlomo said "I said I would be wise, but it is far from me"

Some go further and think a **reasonless** mitzvah shows the Torah's greatness. **The Rambam: absolutely not.** Every mitzvah has a reason; **the more we understand it, the better.** A *chok* is just a mitzvah whose reason **isn't immediately apparent**.

Ask 99 out of 100 Jews why we don't wear **sha'atnez**, or mix **meat and milk**, and they'll say "it's a chok." But the Rishonim all try to give reasons, while conceding they're uncertain.

The Rambam's reasons often relate to idolatry, from what he read:

Mitzvah	The Rambam (Moreh)
Not cutting the pe'ot; not shaving the beard with a razor	That was how **pagan priests** groomed themselves
Sha'atnez	Pagan priests wore **wool and linen together** in their service
Meat and milk	Pagans offered meat and milk together to their gods

The whole Torah, he says, is geared to take us **away from idolatry toward the unity of Hashem**.

Part 4: Astrology Is Nonsense; Astronomy Is Wisdom

All their claims (that this will happen, that a birth under this star brings that) **are all foolishness.** I have **strong proofs that cannot be refuted** against astrology's principles.

(Unfortunately he doesn't bring them here.)

- **Who practised astrology?** The **Chaldeans, Canaanites and Egyptians**.
- **Who rejected it?** The **Greek philosophers**, masters of all the sciences, who mocked it, and the **sages of Persia**.
- "Don't think we reject it because *they* do. We have our own concrete proofs."

A question to think about

What about the **Gemara (Shabbat 156)**: one born under **Mars** (*Ma'adim*) will shed blood, so let him become a **shochet** or **mohel**, "spill blood in a kosher way"? The Rambam addresses such statements directly **at the end of the letter, next week.**

Olivia: didn't Avraham read the stars?

"Firstly, I'm unaware of what you're talking about. It could be I'm laughing at myself, because I'm saying 'I've read it in a book, it must be true!'" But see the next paragraph, which may be what's meant:

Astronomy

The wisdom of the stars (the forms of the spheres, their number, measure and courses, north, south, east and west) **is true and beautiful.** The sages of Greece, Persia and India wrote many books on it. From it you can work out **eclipses**, why the **moon** waxes and wanes and when it will be seen, why days are **long or short**, why two stars rise together but don't set together, why the day is 13 hours in one place and 15, 16 or 20 in another, why day and night are equal in some places, and why **the day lasts six months and the night six months** in others.

- He clearly knew about the far north.
- This is "the calculation of the seasons," a great wisdom that displays our intellect, the expertise of the **tribe of Yissachar** (**יודעי בינה לעתים**).
- **He knew it extremely well.** Hilchot Kiddush HaChodesh, the astronomical chapters on sanctifying the new moon, is "for me probably the most difficult bit in the Mishneh Torah. I've never understood it, and I don't know if I'll ever understand it."

So: **don't equate astrology with astronomy.** If Avraham "read the stars," it means astronomy.

Sandy: the Midrash on Lech Lecha

Hashem took Avram "outside." The Midrash (in :**ויוצא אותו החוצה... הבט נא השמימה וספור הכוכבים** Rashi): **outside the stars**, above their influence; until then he couldn't have children because of his *mazal*. ?Isn't that proof of astrology

"This is actually a much easier Midrash. I'll answer it now." Hashem was telling him: **come out of *thinking* you depend on that**. It's nonsense anyway. The Midrash needn't mean he was actually under its influence. The explicit Gemaras are harder, and the Rambam deals with them next week.

Summary

1. The letter was the Rambam's **first to Provence**, from the Montpellier sages led by **Rabbi Yonatan HaKohen of Lunel**, written in Hebrew around 1194–95, into a region that would later **ban and burn** his books.
2. **Believe only** what is proven by **reason**, perceived by the **senses**, or received from **prophets and the righteous**. Everything else is "the fool believes everything."
3. **"It's written in a book"** is no proof. The worst human illness.
4. Reliance on astrology instead of **self-determination** cost us our **kingdom and Temple**.
5. The Rambam read **every Arabic book on idolatry** (permitted, per the Rivash and Meiri, to refute it and to know what to avoid), and found the **reasons for mitzvot** like pe'ot, sha'atnez and meat and milk.
6. Every mitzvah has a reason; a *chok*'s is just not immediately apparent.
7. **Astrology is nonsense; astronomy is true wisdom.**

Coming Up

Next week (4 February): the rest of the letter: **three views of creation** (Aristotle, Plato, the Torah) and their bearing on providence and reward and punishment; how Hashem acts through intermediaries (the spheres; what **mazal** really means, the "trickling" of energy from Hashem); **free will**; and how to deal with **Talmudic statements that seem to endorse astrology**.

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